

"Go Back to Where You Came From": Blatant Foreigner Discrimination



Ngoc D. Nguyen, McNair Scholar | Stephanie T. Pituc, M.Ed., M.A. | Richard M. Lee, Ph.D.
Department of Psychology, University of Minnesota

Abstract

This study explores the experience of blatant foreigner discrimination, specifically being told, "Go back to where you came from." Approximately 19% of participants reported blatant foreigner discrimination in the past year. To explore group differences in reports, a three-way ANOVA (discrimination x race x nativity) was conducted and found a significant three-way interaction. Separate two-way ANOVAs (discrimination x nativity) by race were conducted and found a significant interaction for Asian Americans. Results from a post-hoc, independent-sample t-test revealed that the positive relationship between blatant foreigner discrimination and psychological distress was greater for immigrant Asian Americans, as opposed to the same relationship for U.S.-born Asian Americans.

Background & Purpose of Study

Racial discrimination has been well-documented as a part of life for racial minorities, and the findings on its negative effects on physical and mental health outcomes are robust (Lee & Ahn, 2011; Paradies, 2006; Williams & Mohammed, 2009). However, the extant psychological literature focuses on racism as a Black-White issue, employing measures initially developed for and used with African American samples (Paradies, 2006). Given the shift in the sociopolitical climate after the attacks of September 11, 2001, it is imperative to examine xenophobic manifestations of racism that frame racial minorities as perpetual foreigners and the problem as Us vs. Them (Oswald, 2005).

The fields of law, political science, and sociology have highlighted historical and contemporary discrimination that casts racial minorities as "foreigners. Several writers note the particular salience of this image for Asians in the US (Huynh et al., 2011; Kim, 1999; Wu, 2002). However, psychology's study of this phenomenon and its effects on mental health are only recently gaining attention (Huynh et al., 2011; Pituc, Jung, Yoo, & Lee, in preparation).

This study seeks to build on this growing literature by extending the scope of foreigner discrimination from subtle to blatant acts. Specifically, we studied the blatant, xenophobic comment, "Go back to where you came from." We explored potential racial group differences in reports of this experience, the correlation with psychological distress, and how this relationship may be different depending upon one's racial and nativity status.

Hypothesis 1: Asian Americans will report more foreigner discrimination than African Americans.

Hypothesis 2: The positive correlation between discrimination and psychological distress will be greater for Asian Americans than African Americans.

Hypothesis 3: Asian Americans who were born in the US will report greater psychological distress than immigrant Asian Americans.

Methods

Participants. Data was collected from two waves of incoming first-year students at the University of Minnesota ($N = 439$) during the Multicultural Center for Academic Excellence (MCAE) orientation event.

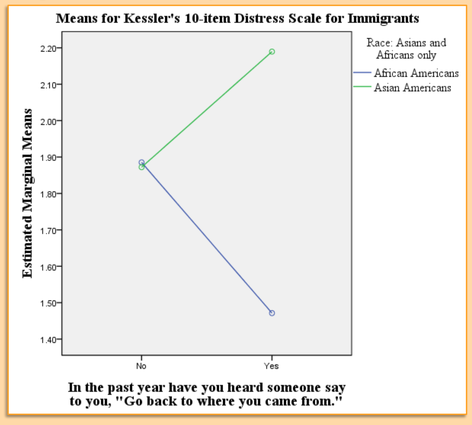
- 63% females and 37% males
- 69% Asian Americans (63% U.S.-born)
- 31% African Americans (66% U.S.-born)

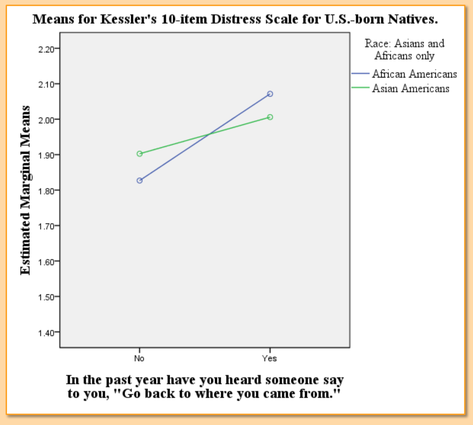
Measures.

- *Demographic variables*: race and nativity (U.S.-born / immigrant)
- *Discrimination*: In the past year, have you heard someone say to you "Go back to where you came from."
- *Psychological distress*: Kessler-10 Scale (Kessler, Andrews, Colpe, Hiripi, Mroczek, Normand et al., 2002)

Results

Figure 1. Three-way interaction split between nativity.





Approximately 19% of participants responded "*Yes*" to the item, "In the past year have you heard someone say to you: 'Go back to where you came from.'"

Hypothesis 1: Asian Americans' and African Americans' reports of blatant foreigner discrimination were not statistically different, X^2 (1, 439) = .008, $p > .05$.

Hypothesis 2: Analyses found a statistically significant correlation between discrimination and psychological distress for Asian Americans, $r = .12$, $n = 301$, $p < .05$, but not for African Americans.

Hypothesis 3: Three-way factorial ANOVA (discrimination [Y/N] x race [Asian Americans/African Americans] x nativity [U.S.-born/immigrant]) found a significant three-way interaction, $F(1,415) = 4.84$, $p < .05$. See figure 1. Separate two-way ANOVAs (discrimination x race) by nativity found a significant interaction among immigrants only for Asian Americans, $F(1, 150) = 5.23$, $p < .05$. For immigrant Asian Americans, there was a significant mean difference on psychological distress between those who responded "Yes" (M=2.19, SD=.52) and those who responded "No" (M=1.87, SD=.63) on blatant foreigner discrimination, $t(107) = -2.05$, $p < .05$.

Discussion and Implications

Results from our study suggest that many Asian Americans and African Americans experience blatant foreigner discrimination, but the potential impact of this xenophobic comment may depend on who the target.

Based on the starkly different immigration histories of African Americans and Asian Americans, we expected Asian Americans to report more foreigner discrimination. However, contrary to our hypothesis, the racial groups reported this experience with equal probability. This may reflect post-9/11, contemporary shifts in xenophobia aimed at all non-White individuals, not just Asian Americans.

Results were supportive of the second hypothesis that the correlation between discrimination and psychological distress would be greatest for Asian Americans. This is consistent with previous research linking awareness of foreigner discrimination and psychological distress and adjustment for Asian Americans (Huynh et al., 2011; Pituc et al., in preparation).

When we looked closer at how nativity status may play a role in the relationship in foreigner discrimination and distress, we noticed some interesting patterns. Immigrant African Americans were the only group for whom foreigner discrimination was negatively related to distress; however this finding was not statistically significant.

We were also surprised to find that although a positive relationship between discrimination and distress was observed for both immigrant and U.S.-born Asian Americans, this relationship was only statistically significant for the immigrant group. We expected a stronger relationship for U.S.-born Asian Americans based on previous research that suggests that discrimination more strongly affects those who may more strongly identify as American (Cheryan & Monin, 2005; Yip, Gee, & Takeuchi, 2008).

The role of racial socialization may explain some of our findings. Racial minorities in the U.S. are more likely to be aware of and expect racial discrimination through both direct and indirect exposure via parents (Hughes, Smith, Stevenson, Rodriguez, Johnson, & Spicer, 2006), peers, school, and other cultural factors. This socialization may blunt the potentially negative consequences. However, Asian immigrants may not be protected to the same degree or may simply not have lived in the U.S. long enough to personally or vicariously experience foreigner discrimination.

Our findings may be limited by methodological issues of sample size and measurement. Other manifestations of blatant foreigner discrimination could be explored. However, the statement "Go back to where you came from," sends a clear message that one is perceived to be an unwelcomed foreigner. It is important to continue exploring this phenomenon and the potency of its effects and target appropriate intervention for groups which may be at-risk.

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